single day, many of whom (mostly teenagers) were blinded by the pellets.[17] Instead of initiating a serious political dialogue, India began to blame Pakistan, a peripheral actor in the protests, for causing the unrest in the first place. In response, on 15 August 2016, the seventieth independence day of India, Modi articulated a shift in India's approach towards Pakistan from the ramparts of the historic Red Fort as such: 'I want to express my gratitude to the people of Balochistan, Gilgit, and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, for the way they whole-heartedly thanked me, the way they expressed gratitude to me ... people of a distant land I haven't even seen ... when they thank the Indian prime minister, it's an honour for the 125 crore people of the country'.[18]

What for, and how, the people of these regions had thanked Modi was left unsaid. The implicit message was that India was capable of, and perhaps already exercising (both via Afghanistan and otherwise), covert intervention in Pakistan's internal troubles. The mention of Pakistan's domestic fault-lines at the Independence Day celebrations in response to unrest in Kashmir, among other issues, was unprecedented. Whether this was empty rhetoric, as in the 1960s when Indian parliamentarians sought to support the Pashtun and Baloch insurgencies in the wake of the 1965 war, or a true shift in India's security practices like the early 1970s when Indira Gandhi proactively supported the Baloch insurgency, is yet to be seen. But if one is to go by optics, India was now intent on exploiting Pakistan's fear of strategic encirclement and India's role in exerting diplomatic pressure on Pakistan's human rights violations in Balochistan and Gilgit-Baltistan. That this statement came at a time of high toxicity in Afghanistan-Pakistan relations made it even more potent.

Parallel to worsening India-Pakistan relations, Kabul's relations with Islamabad also took a nosedive after December 2015. Afghan outreach had been dependent on Pakistan's willingness and capacity to bring different Afghan Taliban factions to the table, not all of which were interested in talking. The gambit failed. Instead of expecting to meet the Taliban at the negotiating table, on 10 August 2015, a massive bomb blast rocked Kabul, killing scores of people.[19] This blast was one of the many that had come to wreak havoc in Afghanistan, but its intensity shocked most Afghans. The attack underlined that if Pakistan was expecting to convert Mullah Omar's death into an opportunity to consolidate its